



The Journey

By Aliyah Karaki

My HSC journey has been a rollercoaster of emotions, challenges, and growth. I started as a student who wasn't very confident in my abilities. I didn't attend a selective school, and in an environment where many of my peers seemed to have access to more resources or opportunities, it was easy to feel like the odds were stacked against me. Coming from a Lebanese background, I was often aware of the stereotypes and assumptions people made about me. There were moments when it felt like I had to work twice as hard to prove myself, not just academically but also against the biases that came with my cultural identity. Yet, as I look back, I realise that those very challenges became my greatest motivators.

In the beginning, I struggled with self-belief. Every assessment felt like a mountain I wasn't equipped to climb. However, I was fortunate to have an incredible support system. My family's unwavering faith in me pushed me to keep going, even on days when I felt like giving up. My tutors played a pivotal role, not only in teaching me the content but also in showing me the importance of discipline, resilience, and self-belief. Their encouragement made me realise that success wasn't reserved for those who had all the advantages but for those who were willing to work for it.

There were many late nights, countless practice papers, and moments of self-doubt. But as the months passed, I started to see progress. I began to believe in myself and trust the process.

I learned that hard work truly does pay off and that perseverance can break barriers that seem insurmountable. Each small victory, whether it was a better-than-expected result or mastering a difficult concept, fuelled my determination to aim higher.

When the HSC exams finally came, I felt a mix of nerves and readiness. I had poured my heart into my studies, and although I didn't know what the outcome would be, I was proud of how far I had come. Receiving an ATAR of 99.25 was a moment of pure disbelief and joy, it was a mark I never believed I would be able to achieve. It was a culmination of not just my efforts but also the sacrifices and support of those around me and has unlocked doors to my future that seemed impossible.

This journey taught me invaluable lessons. It showed me that believing in yourself, even when it feels impossible, can change everything. It reaffirmed the power of hard work and the importance of having people who uplift you. To my tutors, thank you for your patience and dedication. To my family, thank you for always being my rock. And to anyone reading this who might feel like they're not good enough: you are capable of more than you know. Trust yourself, embrace the challenges, and never underestimate what you can achieve with determination and support.

The HSC was more than just an academic milestone for me; it was a journey of self-discovery and growth. And while the ATAR is just a number, the lessons I've learned will stay with me for a lifetime.

